

FIRST FRUIT

There has been much preaching in the Church on tithing, but precious little teaching on the principle of first fruit. (How many of you truly know what is meant by the term “*First fruit*”?)

If we are going to live the God life, we must learn to put first things first. In so doing, God must occupy the number one slot in our life.

The Bible has much to say about money:

- There are 500 Scriptures in the Bible concerning prayer...
- There are 500 verses concerning faith...
- There are more than 2,000 Scriptures concerning money and possessions...
- Jesus talked about money in 16 of His 38 parables...

Money is a test from God. It is a priority test!
Are we passing or failing? (Be honest with
yourself)

According to Scripture the way we handle our
money speaks volumes about where our
priorities have been placed. Matthew 6:19-21
(NLT) ***“Don’t store up treasures here on earth,
where they can be eaten by moths and get
rusty, and where thieves break in and steal. 20
Store your treasures in heaven, where they will
never become moth-eaten or rusty and where
they will be safe from thieves. 21 Wherever
your treasure is, there your heart and thoughts
will also be.”***

The principle of first fruit was established in the
Old Testament book of Exodus. Exodus
13:2,12,13 (NLT) ***“Dedicate to me all the
firstborn sons of Israel and every firstborn
male animal. They are mine.” 12 All firstborn
sons and firstborn male animals must be***

presented to the LORD. 13 A firstborn male donkey may be redeemed from the LORD by presenting a lamb in its place. But if you decide not to make the exchange, the donkey must be killed by breaking its neck. However, you must redeem every firstborn son.”

God declared the firstborn belonged to Him 16 times in Scripture! When an animal delivered its firstborn, it was to be sacrificed and if for some reason it was considered unclean, the person was to take a clean animal from their herd and sacrifice it, thus redeeming the firstborn.

Jesus was Gods firstborn and He offered him as a sacrifice. He was a real first fruit offering, in that sense He was Gods tithe! God gave His tithe in faith before we ever believed. Romans 8:29 (NLT) ***“For God knew his people in advance, and he chose them to become like his***

Son, so that his Son would be the firstborn, with many brothers and sisters.”

The Scripture is clear, God not only requires the firstborn or the first fruit, but He set the example by giving His firstborn Son, for the sins of His other sons.

In the same way, we are to bring the first fruit -and THEN we will see the blessing.

Some people want to wait until they can afford to start tithing, but the curse and the devourer will never allow them to be in a financial position to do so. I recently had a conversation with a person who was not tithing, and I told them, *“It does not matter how many resources you are able to attract, you will never have enough, because you are placing your resources in a sack that has holes in it!”*

It is interesting to note that God required the firstborn. He did not say to allow the ewe to bear nine lambs and then give number ten to Him. It is possible to be a tither without adhering to the principle of first fruit. First fruit is giving Him a minimum of 10% BEFORE we access any of the 100%!

It doesn't take faith to give one out of ten, but it requires great faith to give the first of ten!

Have you ever wondered why God respected Abel's offering but rejected Cain's? Genesis 4:3-5 (KJV) "***And in process of time it came to pass, that Cain brought of the fruit of the ground an offering unto the LORD. 4 And Abel, he also brought of the firstlings of his flock and of the fat thereof. And the LORD had respect unto Abel and to his offering: 5 But unto Cain and to his offering he had not respect. And Cain was very wroth, and his countenance fell.***" Abel brought the firstborn;

Cain brought his offering in the process of time. When he decided to. When he got around to it!

What we give to God is never lost because He redeems it for us, but what we withhold from him will always be lost. The reason for the loss is that our possessions no longer have the redemptive power of God working for them.

Matthew 16:25 (NLT) ***“If you try to keep your life for yourself, you will lose it. But if you give up your life for me, you will find true life.”***

What are we to do with the first fruit? Proverbs 3:9-10 (NKJV) ***“Honor the LORD with your possessions, And with the first-fruits of all your increase; 10 So your barns will be filled with plenty, And your vats will overflow with new wine.”*** These verses point out the following principles:

- Tithing is a priority of God... ***“Honor the Lord with your possessions...”***

- The first fruit is required... Honor him, “... ***With the first fruits of your increase...***”
- We will experience Gods provision... “***Your barns will be filled with plenty...***”
- We can expect Him to bless us in a spiritual sense... “***Your vats will overflow with new wine...***”

Just as the firstborn and first fruit belong to God, the tithe belongs to Him as well. Leviticus 27:30 (NKJV) “***And all the tithe of the land, whether of the seed of the land or of the fruit of the tree, is the LORD’s. It is holy to the LORD.***”

Some will say that tithing is a principle of the Law, but tithing actually predates the Law by 400 years and according to Jesus, postdates the Law! Malachi 3:6 (NKJV) “***For I am the LORD, I do not change...***” Romans 11:16 (NKJV) “***For if the first fruit is holy, the lump***

is also holy; and if the root is holy, so are the branches. Matthew 23:23 (NLT) ***“How terrible it will be for you teachers of religious law and you Pharisees. Hypocrites! For you are careful to tithe even the tiniest part of your income, but you ignore the important things of the law—justice, mercy, and faith. You should tithe, yes, but you should not leave undone the more important things.”***

Many blessings are promised to those who become tithers, but the first fruit offering is the trigger on the blessing. I hope you will pull the trigger today!

CONCLUSION:

The following principles should be followed when engaging in tithing the first fruit:

- The tithe of first fruit is 10% of total family income...
- The tithe of first fruit belongs in the local church...

- The tithe of first fruit should never be directed or earmarked...
- The tithe of first fruit should be in God's house before one dime of the income is spent...